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Whiteness in Catholic Theological Method

Karen Teel*

This article argues that an attitude of whiteness characterizes conventional methodological approaches in the fields of theology and religion. Using examples drawn from the discipline of Christian theology, I contend that scholars have a responsibility to address white supremacy; I describe whiteness as an attitude and expose it in theological method by deploying the concept of racist thinking to analyze Terrence W. Tilley's argument in *The Disciples' Jesus*; and I compare M. Shawn Copeland's *Enfleshing Freedom* as a work that exhibits antiracist thinking. Positing that the problem of whiteness pervades the disciplines of theology and religious studies generally, I conclude that, to construct adequate and relevant arguments, we must critically engage whiteness.

Methodologies are not benign; scholars have commitments in their work.

—Mitchem 2002, 77

SINCE THE 2016 US presidential election, the continuing significance of racialization has become evident, even to many who previously believed the nation had largely moved past it. Religionists and theologians frequently mention social issues such as this in our scholarship, whether

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as starting points, relevant examples, or realities to which we hope our conclusions will speak. Collectively, however, we have yet to develop a consistent pan-disciplinary commitment to addressing racial inequity, whether in society or in our field, much less specific methods for doing so. While some scholars seamlessly engage the history and present status of white supremacy—which is at the root of racial inequity—many, including most white scholars, address it superficially or not at all. Is this a problem? What does it reveal about our commitments? Are we free to set aside the issue of white supremacy, or does doing so perpetuate a breakdown in our methods?

As a white, US, confessionally Roman Catholic, conventionally trained theologian, I see our collective failure to engage white supremacy as a problem that is particularly urgent. Both as a scholar and as a person of faith, I affirm that racism and white supremacy egregiously violate basic tenets of Christianity, including the dignity of each person as made in the image of God and the call to solidarity within the human family. I also recognize that racism and white supremacy have shaped US Christianity, just as they have shaped other social institutions. Indeed, an increasing number of thinkers argue convincingly that Christianity actually created modern white supremacy (see, e.g., [Perkinson 2004](#); [Brown Douglas 2005](#); [Carter 2008](#); [Jennings 2010](#); [Hill Fletcher 2017](#)). Thus, although all religion scholars should address white supremacy, Christian theologians have a particular obligation to do so.

While theologians of color have long critiqued the ways in which the discipline of theology has performed white supremacy, white theologians are just beginning to do this work. For example, Tom Beaudoin and Katherine Turpin expose the field of practical theology as having emerged within a white supremacist context and as culturally white rather than neutral or universal, as it imagines itself ([Beaudoin and Turpin 2014](#)). They assert that “white theology manifests a proprietary spirit about universal things through sustained indifference to particular, diverse forms of living” ([Beaudoin and Turpin 2014](#), 254). Indeed, in enumerating some characteristics of “white theology,” Beaudoin and Turpin identify the very assumption that the field is universal as one symptom of its whiteness.¹ Here, I seek to develop this idea of whiteness as an attitude and to demonstrate that it functions to the detriment of conventional theological method. Although I draw these examples from my own theological discipline, I am convinced that whiteness as a methodological problem pervades the fields of theology and religious studies.

¹Beaudoin and Turpin’s chapter has an affinity with Shawn [Kelley’s \(2002\)](#) study of racism as part of the foundation of modern biblical studies and George [Yancy’s \(2008\)](#) recognition of philosophy as suffused with culturally white values and assumptions.

The article proceeds in three parts. First, I define white supremacy and contend that religion scholars, particularly theologians, must address it. Second, I describe whiteness as an attitude and expose its inner workings by deploying sociologist Steve Martinot's concept of "racist thinking" to analyze Terrence W. Tilley's argument in *The Disciples' Jesus* (Tilley 2008). Third, I compare M. Shawn Copeland's *Enfleshing Freedom* (Copeland 2010) as a work that exhibits what I call "antiracist thinking." I aim to distinguish methodological differences that shed light on how these two quintessentially Catholic theologies yield such different results. Because Tilley is racialized as white and Copeland as black, it may seem obvious that Tilley's work would exhibit whiteness, whereas Copeland's would not. I maintain, however, that this is not inevitable: It is not the fact that these thinkers are racialized differently but their differential awareness of white supremacy and of their own racialization that generates the presence and absence of racist thinking in their respective arguments. I conclude that to construct adequate and relevant scholarship, US theologians and religionists must critically engage white supremacy, including our own whiteness.

WHITE SUPREMACY'S CLAIM ON RELIGIONISTS AND THEOLOGIANIS

Philosopher Charles Mills observes, "White supremacy is the unnamed political system that has made the modern world what it is today" (Mills 1997, 1). With the expression "white supremacy," I indicate the racially hierarchical system of social and political organization that developed during the era of European colonialism and persists to the present. White supremacy, and whiteness as a racial identity, initially developed as a means to justify Europeans' power to enslave Africans and take Native Americans' land in pursuit of profit. In this sense, white supremacy refers most properly neither to white people *per se* nor to interpersonal acts of racism but to a political, social, economic, and religious system of domination.

This system manifests differently across the world. In the United States, white supremacy confers unearned advantages upon people who appear to be of unmixed European ancestry, or "white," and unearned disadvantages upon people who appear to be black, nonwhite, or of mixed ancestry. The racial identities of "white" and "black" are set in opposition. Black people can never receive the benefits of whiteness, unless their looks allow them to "pass" for white and they are prepared to deny their African ancestry and adopt a white cultural identity. Whites have assigned Asian Americans and Latinos to comparatively flexible positions in the racial hierarchy, somewhere between white and black. As well, whites

often consider indigenous US Americans to have a specific racial identity, but the people upon whose homelands the United States was built may disagree, deeming “Native American” or “American Indian” a political identity incorporating disparate tribes and nations.² Although most scientists now agree that race is a social construct without a sound basis in biology, racialization continues to shape the ways we relate to one another and to have tremendous social and political significance.³

We do not always agree about the nature of this significance. On the one hand, for their entire history in what is now in the United States, communities of color have been resisting white supremacy and its destructive effects. Think of the many subtle and overt forms of rebellion deployed by Africans and black people from slavery to the present; or of the eloquence and armed resistance of Native Americans in the face of white attack as well as their ongoing work to recover and sustain their lifeways; or of Asian American, Latinoa, and Arab American efforts to participate fully in building US communities and prosperity. As a result, many people do not need proof that white supremacy obtains, nor do they need a careful explanation that the claim that it does is not an indictment of all white people as evil; they know or intuit this from experience. On the other hand, many people, especially whites, who are committed to a narrative of progress believe that equality is all but achieved, at least in our minds (which, we think, is what really counts). This disconnect can lead to communication challenges. For example, one day during a class discussion, a white student objected to my use of the phrase “white supremacy” to describe our everyday sociopolitical context in the United States. He argued that “white supremacy” evokes the Ku Klux Klan, while “good white people,” most white people, just are not like that. He worried that the phrase would turn off well-intentioned folks who might otherwise be willing to discuss race. In response, a black student shrugged and remarked that for him the phrase did not evoke extremism: “To me, white supremacy is just, you know, politics.” The class agreed that we had to work hard to establish common ground before we could even begin a substantive conversation about race. On one level, this article constitutes an attempt to lay precisely this kind of groundwork for religious studies and theological scholars.

For those who need proof, the continuing existence of white supremacy is amply documented. Whether we consider employment, education,

²I am grateful to an anonymous reviewer and to Persephone Hooper-Lewis of the University of San Diego for drawing my attention to this point.

³Steve Martinot gives a cogent explanation of how race and racialization were constructed and remain foundational to US society in [Martinot 2010](#), 20–26.

homeownership and other forms of wealth accumulation, incarceration rates, infant mortality rates, or adoption rates, rigorous social scientific research shows that, controlling for all other factors, white people achieve desirable outcomes more often and with less trouble than equally qualified nonwhites.⁴ White people—those perceived to have solely European ancestry—are unfairly advantaged by white supremacy, whether or not we intend it. This is not primarily because of conscious discrimination by the masses of white people, although discrimination based on skin color is the “commonsense” definition of racism, and of course it does still occur.⁵ Rather, these inequalities exist because of the bias favoring white people that framed US society when it was created and that still undergirds the often unintentional bias that remains so common as to be normal.

White supremacy, then, is a foundational aspect of US life. One way or another, we all experience its effects. What this means for white people is that, regardless of our personal commitments, we benefit from white supremacy. In our everyday lives, we receive unearned racial advantages.⁶ As Katie Walker Grimes (2017, xxiii) points out, we are not simply complicit; we are active participants. If our participation is invisible to us, this does not mean that we have no responsibility to address it. It means that society is constructed in such a way as to enable and encourage us to ignore it, to see it not as unjust but simply as business as usual. In fact, describing the problem in terms of statistics, as I have done in the previous paragraph and which can be a useful and necessary first step in getting (white) people to comprehend that these advantages exist at all, often unhelpfully obscures the fact that these advantages do not occur apart from white people’s individual lives but precisely in our everyday experiences. They are the direct result of the disadvantaging of our peers. For example, when store security guards follow shoppers of color rather than white people, whites enjoy hassle-free shopping because of the inconvenience that people of color are actually experiencing. When white job applicants—including college faculty—are interviewed and hired more often than nonwhite job applicants, white people receive disproportionate access to financial security at the expense of nonwhite people’s ability to feed their families. And when

⁴Studies are numerous and readily available. Here are a few examples. For employment, consider Bertrand and Mullainathan 2004; Pager 2003; DiTomaso 2013. For infant mortality rates, see Centers for Disease Control 2015. For adoption rates, see Maldonado 2005–6.

⁵I borrow the phrase “commonsense racism” from Bryan Massingale (see Massingale 2010, 13–15).

⁶Perhaps the best-known conceptualization of this problem remains Peggy McIntosh’s description of white privilege as an “invisible knapsack” of advantages (McIntosh 2008). Another lucid white proponent of the dangers of white advantage—though he has also been roundly critiqued for abusing his own white privilege—is Tim Wise; see especially Wise 2008, 2012. On white complicity and the need for vigilance, see Applebaum 2010.

white babies are adopted before black babies, black babies wait longer for permanent homes, for reasons that have nothing to do with what they need or deserve. Benefiting from these disparities, white US Americans cannot choose not to participate in white supremacy. White supremacy is a present and pressing issue.

Although white supremacy is relevant to all scholars of religion, I contend that it represents a particularly urgent problem for theologians. Using the language of the Bible, a most authoritative source for Christian theology, we can say that for the entire history of what is now the United States, over five hundred years, white supremacy has been a “sign of the times,” perhaps *the* “sign of the times” (Matthew 16:3, NAB). According to the Catholic bishops who convened at the Second Vatican Council, the “signs of the times” not only merit but require our attention ([Vatican Council II 1996](#), 165). White supremacy, then, warrants the attention of ordinary Christians as well as formal theological investigation.

Moreover, white supremacy is not simply one among many topics available for consideration, one that religionists and theologians can set aside without consequence. There are at least two reasons for this. First, given its foundational role in the development of the modern world, including the United States, white supremacy is relevant to virtually every justice issue that arises in our social, political, and ecclesial contexts. Poverty, education, the environment, politics, religion—you name it, race is a factor. To omit consideration of race is to miss the big picture. Second, scholars are members of society just as much as nonscholars, and as such we too participate personally in white supremacy. This means that we must grapple with it not merely as a system “out there” that we can objectively observe and analyze, but as a system in which we personally and collectively are actively involved. Indicting society in general, or white people other than ourselves, for white supremacy while ignoring our role in it would be hypocritical. Moreover, if as scholars we claim to be working in the pursuit and service of truth, then not recognizing the significance of white supremacy or our participation in it is—returning for a moment to Christian language—a sin of omission, a form of culpable ignorance. Most thinkers I know do not aspire to be hypocrites or sinners; nor do we want the efficacy of our arguments to be diminished by the discernible presence of such tendencies. For these reasons, US religionists and theologians endeavoring to address concrete issues must engage white supremacy explicitly, both as a social, political, and ecclesial system that exists independently of our individual actions and as a problematic (sinful) structure in which we personally participate.

I contend, then, that white supremacy has a special claim on US theologians and religionists. As a theologian, I tend to speak in Christian idiom. Scholars in other disciplines may frame their moral obligations differently. But however we articulate our warrants, we cannot responsibly ignore white supremacy. It need not be the only problem we address, but serious engagement with it must form part of the background of any scholarly analysis that aims to be socially, politically, or ecclesially relevant.

I am by no means the first to mount this argument. Joseph R. [Nearon \(1974, 1975\)](#) began exhorting the Catholic Theological Society of America to confront racism in the 1970s. The late James H. Cone is perhaps the best-known Protestant thinker who has identified “theology’s great sin” as “silence in the face of white supremacy” and called white theologians to account ([Cone 2004](#); see also [Cone 1986](#), 50–60). M. Shawn [Copeland \(2002\)](#) has examined racism as it relates to the vocation of the theologian, and Bryan N. [Massingale \(2014\)](#) recently issued another call to white Catholic ethicists to take up this problem. Black thinkers such as these are not responsible to the history and legacy of white supremacy in the same way as white thinkers, yet they courageously refuse to concede our discipline and Christian faith itself to the vagaries of white supremacy. Although a growing number of white theologians are investigating white supremacy as central to our work and lives (e.g., see [Andolsen 1986](#); [Thistlethwaite 1989](#); [Hobgood 2000](#); [Perkinson 2004](#); [Nilson 2007](#); [Cassidy and Mikulich 2007](#); [Teel 2010](#); [Pramuk 2013](#); [Harvey 2014](#); [Vasko 2015](#); [Grimes 2017](#)), many white theologians have not substantively addressed it. How are we able, so continuously and successfully, to withstand the logic and pathos of such arguments? What are the thought processes by which we manage to ignore their intellectual and moral claim on us?

WHITENESS IN CATHOLIC THEOLOGICAL METHOD

To begin to answer this question, I propose a theory of whiteness as an attitude. This theory proves theologically illuminating insofar as the attitude of whiteness can be identified as a traditional component of conventional theological methodology. In this section, first I survey several established understandings of the concept of whiteness—which, as will become clear, does not simply indicate all white people, nor only white people—and introduce my usage of the term to denote an attitude, often held inadvertently. I argue that where it appears in theology, the attitude of whiteness constitutes a methodological problem. Second, I draw on the work of sociologist Steve Martinot to identify “racist thinking” as a key thought pattern comprising this methodology. Third, I discern this attitude of whiteness in a contemporary constructive work by a white

US Catholic theologian, namely Terrence W. Tilley's *The Disciples' Jesus: Christology as Reconciling Practice* (2008). If racist thinking appears in the work of a learned, well-intentioned, and highly respected leader in our discipline, then we have good reason to suspect that it broadly pervades our field.

Whiteness

In the racial hierarchy that structures the United States, the term "white" refers to persons of solely European ancestry. According to this ideology of racialization, such persons, and only such persons, are expected to check the "white" box or write in "Caucasian" on the census. In everyday life, however, whiteness is not so neatly circumscribed. This is because, regardless of ancestry or self-identification, race is socially constructed such that anyone who appears to have solely European ancestry will be treated as white, absent information to the contrary.

As a case in point, consider that the US census counts race and Hispanic origin as separate categories. People of Hispanic, Latinoa/Latin American, or Spanish heritage may have any racial identity, including white. In other words, whereas cultural identity may be claimed by individuals, racial identity is assigned by society. Now, some people who identify culturally as Hispanic also happen to "look" Hispanic ("racially"), but some do not. This means that one can be culturally Hispanic and simultaneously be racialized as white and accorded white privilege. If we are surprised to discover that a person we assumed was white is of Mexican descent (for example), then our sense of being involved in a case of mistaken identity illustrates the fact that "white" has come to function not only as a racial identity but as a cultural one—albeit one strangely lacking in easily identifiable content, as when whites claim to be "just American."

The so-called "white race," like the idea of a social hierarchy based on race, did not always exist; it was invented as a component of white supremacy.⁷ Now that it has become normalized, we deploy the descriptor *white* to nominate a specific identity: one can identify as white just as one can identify as black, brown, Asian, Indian, etc. While we can speak of "white people" collectively, as a racial group, *white* also names a culture with distinctive social conventions, habits, beliefs, and attitudes. Those socialized into whiteness are often but not always racially white; one can be racially white and identify with nonwhite culture, and one can be racially nonwhite and identify with white culture. Cultural whiteness, rather

⁷Seminal texts on the invention of the white race include Jordan 2012; Roediger 2005 and 2007; Ignatiev 2008; and Painter 2010.

than whiteness as racial identity including all apparently white people, is the general topic of this discussion.

In the context of white supremacy, it is common for white people to exhibit whiteness and nonwhite people to resist it. But white people can exhibit antiracist thinking, and nonwhite people can exhibit racist thinking. Again, this is because, as a cultural identity, whiteness is not simply coextensive with all racially white people; whites can try to opt out, and nonwhites can try to opt in. Likewise, in academic scholarship, whiteness is not present to the same extent in all works by white thinkers, nor is it necessarily absent from the works of nonwhite thinkers. In this article, which compares the work of two scholars, the author whose work exhibits racist thinking is racialized as white, and the author whose work exhibits antiracist thinking is racialized as black. Although not surprising, this is not inevitable; neither is it mere happenstance, because most whites are socially conditioned to identify (often unconsciously) with white culture and many nonwhites to oppose it. Shaped but finally unconstrained by racial boundaries—which, after all, were always artificial—whiteness takes on a life of its own.

Defining Whiteness

Scholars describe whiteness variously. Perhaps most famously, Peggy McIntosh (2008) depicts white privilege as the unwitting enjoyment of unearned social advantages: being able to spend most of one's time around people of one's own race; knowing that the "person in charge" in most situations is likely to share one's race; seeing one's racial identity positively represented in the news; not having to teach one's (white) children about racism for their own protection, and so on. The term "white privilege" can be misleading because it sounds positive but actually refers to unjust racial inequities that should be rejected. Still, perhaps because it is less off-putting to the racially unaware than phrases like "white domination" or "white supremacy," it remains a popular way of beginning conversations about whiteness.

Some theorists frame whiteness as performance. To distinguish culturally white behavior and attitudes from racially white people, as I do above, Marilyn Frye (1992, 147–69) adopts the term *whiteness*. Janet Helms (2007) reassures whites that if we do the hard work of learning about racism and become actively antiracist, then our race can be "a nice thing to have" rather than something of which to be ignorant or ashamed. Sara Ahmed (2004) warns against the "non-performativity" of anti-racist declarations: despite what I may hope and believe, stating that I am not or do not intend to be racist does not guarantee that my attitudes and

behaviors will not be racist. Noel Ignatiev (racetractor.org) holds that “treason to whiteness is loyalty to humanity,” *whiteness* here being roughly equivalent to white supremacy and *humanity* inclusive of all people, even whites. In these interpretations, whiteness resides in the actions of white people.

In another vein, legal scholar Cheryl Harris (1993) proposes that over the centuries whiteness has come to be treated as a form of property in which rights and privileges are invested and protected by the courts. Theologian Kelly Brown Douglas (2015) extends Harris’s idea of whiteness as property in the wake of the not-guilty verdict for George Zimmerman, a white-Hispanic man who killed an African American teenager named Trayvon Martin. Brown Douglas analyzes the notion of the right to “stand your ground,” which is coded into law in several states and was invoked by at least one juror following Zimmerman’s trial, even though the judge had not instructed the jury to apply this standard. Brown Douglas argues that “stand your ground” applies to whites perceiving others as threats and not to black and brown bodies under attack. Only such a perspective explains how Zimmerman’s aggressive pursuit of an innocent teenager could be interpreted as self-defense, whereas Martin’s attempt to defend himself once caught was seen as justification for Zimmerman’s use of deadly force rather than as standing his own ground. Whether the whiteness being defended was the nation’s property, the neighborhood’s, or Zimmerman’s own, Brown Douglas concludes that Martin’s very presence constituted trespass.

Finally, some scholars describe an intellectual and affective dimension of whiteness. Critical theorist Peter McLaren depicts whiteness as a sort of collective willful ignorance, “a sociohistorical form of consciousness” that includes “a form of social amnesia” (McLaren 1998, 66). Philosopher George Yancy identifies whiteness as a feeling of racial nonspecificity, neutrality, or normalcy. “For white people,” Yancy explains, “whiteness is the transcendental norm in terms of which they live their lives as persons, individuals. People of color, however, confront whiteness in their everyday lives, not as an abstract concept but in the form of embodied whites who engage in racist practices that negatively affect their lives” (Yancy 2012, 7). Yancy’s analysis makes clear that in a white supremacist society such as the United States, whiteness generates experiences that are not the same for everyone. There is a gap between the experiences of white people and the experiences of people of color. For the former, whiteness is neutral, even benevolent; for the latter, whiteness is a problem.

I want to try to bridge this gap, or at least make it possible to discuss it, by emphasizing yet another aspect of whiteness. I propose that we

can correlate the experiences grounding both perspectives and begin to create common ground if we view whiteness as an attitude. My account builds most immediately on the views of whiteness as performance and on McLaren's and Yancy's insight that whiteness seems normal, rather than racist, to white people.

The attitude of whiteness, then, manifests in discernible thought patterns that correspond to, and arise along with, the feeling that to be white is to be normal or neutral. A key element of this feeling of normalcy is to deny, ignore, or fail to notice the fact that whites exercise unearned social power and specifically that whites "engage[s] in racist practices that negatively affect [the] lives" of people of color (Yancy 2012, 7). Angelina E. Castagno uses the term *powerblindness* to indicate "our reluctance and avoidance of race, social class, language, gender, sexuality, and other politicized aspects of identity that are linked to power and the distribution of resources in the United States. ... [P]owerblind sameness refers to the denial of power-related difference" (Castagno 2013, 108). Castagno's concept of powerblind sameness includes but is not limited to colorblindness as described by Eduardo Bonilla-Silva (2006). Whiteness is powerblind Eurocentrism.

Whiteness in Theology

In theology, we can detect the presence of the attitude of whiteness insofar as the discipline is structured by white European and white American cultural sensibilities, and the collective academy has rarely considered this fact to be worth noticing, let alone contesting. As Beaudoin and Turpin state, "white theology need never declare its own racial-ethnic home base, because of the historically granted advantage of not thinking of itself as having one" (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 254). Describing how white cultural values, assumptions, and practices frame and dominate their field, Beaudoin and Turpin note that typically whiteness is not consciously white supremacist or malicious, and that addressing it is a challenging task because it is designed to be invisible, to feel normal (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 253; see also McIntosh 2008). For the purpose of their argument, by "white practical theologians," Beaudoin and Turpin indicate practical theologians who identify as white. Discussing several examples, including some from their own publications, Beaudoin and Turpin illuminate how "many white practical theologians write as if the Christian tradition can be invoked in uncomplicated ways without interrogating how it has been intertwined with the ideals of white racial domination" (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 261–62). For Beaudoin and Turpin, white practical theologians typically perform their field's whiteness with utter

confidence in their ability to speak universal truth, with virtually no hint of racial self-awareness, and without malice.

Beaudoin and Turpin identify five characteristics of white theology. First, white theology focuses on the individual; “the history of the field is told as a story of successive pioneering theologians who introduced new concepts” (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 255). Second, white theology evidences a strong belief in progress, that we have the power to shape history to the ends we desire (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 255–56). Third, white theology has historically functioned to serve and promote white supremacy (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 257). Fourth, white theology highly values orderliness and procedural clarity (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 258–59). Fifth, white theology assumes that we live in a meritocracy (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 259–60). By enumerating these characteristics, Beaudoin and Turpin begin to expose how culturally specific beliefs, practices, and assumptions are associated with being racialized as white and doing practical theology. For example, they identify ignoring practical theologies produced by people of color as a lamentable trend among white practical theologians (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 258).

In focusing on white thinkers, and not presuming to discuss what the whiteness of the field may mean for practical theologians of color, Beaudoin and Turpin exercise appropriate restraint. Yet the key features of white practical theology that they identify—focus on the individual, a belief in progress, (unwitting) support of white supremacy, love of order and procedural clarity, and commitment to meritocracy—are not simply idiosyncratic characteristics of works produced by theologians who are racialized as white. Beaudoin and Turpin clarify, “White practical theology is not an approach to practical theology as much as it is a recognition of a deep structure for theologizing. White scholars cannot take it or leave it” (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 267). In this sense, it is clear that the adjective *white* modifies the discipline, rather than merely naming the racialization or approach of certain practitioners. Whiteness shapes the discipline itself.

Beaudoin and Turpin refrain from unrealistic exhortations to end or transcend the field’s whiteness. Their description makes clear that this pernicious problem will not be solved by simplistic measures such as solidarity statements from white theologians. Nor would it necessarily be eliminated if white scholars were to exit the field en masse. Rather, Beaudoin and Turpin urge white theologians to acknowledge the problem and undertake to develop a “color-conscious critically white theology” (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 267).

From this analysis we can conclude that, although white theologians should watch out for whiteness, it is not only an issue for us. If whiteness frames the discipline, then all scholars trained in that discipline would have to expend conscious effort to avoid replicating whiteness in their work. Moreover, any effort to critique, resist, or diminish the whiteness of the field would run the risk of being dismissed as inauthentic, as “not really theology.” (My sense is that white and nonwhite scholars bear this risk unevenly. At conferences I sometimes hear my work on theology and race described as “cutting-edge”; meanwhile, the theologians of color whose work inspires my own are relegated to special topic sessions, lumped together and tokenized as bringing “the race perspective” as though it is a sort of embellishment or afterthought to the main event of serious theological inquiry.) In various ways, established disciplinary norms militate against the recognition, let alone resistance, of the field’s whiteness. It is therefore entirely possible, even inevitable, for nonwhites to work within the field’s white framework, such that they may also produce white practical theology.

If Beaudoin and Turpin’s analysis is correct, then nonwhite theologians find themselves navigating a field that was constructed for and by white people according to white supremacist norms to which many white people, including some scholars, remain functionally oblivious. On top of that, because until recently only white people could access advanced theological training, nonwhite theologians negotiate the status of being relative newcomers to the discipline who must prove to senior white colleagues, the field’s gatekeepers, that they are qualified to participate and that they are producing “real theology.” In such a context, it would be hardly surprising to find at least some nonwhite theologians producing white theology. Indeed, one begins to suspect that, just like white theologians, nonwhite theologians must prove that they can produce white theology in order to earn PhDs, obtain faculty positions, and attain tenure. It is part of the job.

That said, this article does not seek to uncover whiteness in a non-white theologian’s work. Having created and perpetuated the problem of whiteness, I believe that we whites bear the burden of responsibility for remedying it. It is not my place to prescribe how people of color should respond. I also want to buck the trend in which scholars either critique or condescendingly commend colleagues of color for engaging race, and celebrate white colleagues who ignore it. For these reasons, while I maintain that either attitude can characterize any scholar’s work, here I analyze what is arguably the most common configuration: racist thinking in a white scholar’s work and antiracist thinking in a nonwhite scholar’s

work. In doing so, I hope to trouble the assumption that scholars who operate according to the field's conventions, which include ignoring white supremacy, necessarily produce the best possible theology, whereas scholars who address white supremacy typically produce theology that is less "theological" because it is more "political." The field belongs to all of us, and I hope to advance a shared vocabulary that we can use, together and separately, to expose and dismantle its whiteness.

Modestly, Beaudoin and Turpin limit their exploratory remarks to their field of practical theology. Historically speaking, however, not only practical theology but theology in general arose and has been maintained as a culturally white field. It is therefore reasonable to ask whether all mainstream theological disciplines—and religious studies more broadly—suffer from whiteness. I believe that they do. The examples in this article begin to uncover and describe this foundational problem in Christian systematic theology, specifically Christology.

Beaudoin and Turpin are right to frame whiteness as constitutive of their field rather than simply as one possible approach to their field, as though white scholars can deal with this problem simply by disavowing it. Whiteness is not an attitude that we can simply decide to take or leave, to adopt or not; we cannot change it as readily as children might change their attitude about eating vegetables, or faculty about committee work. Keeping in mind this dimension of whiteness as ultimately beyond our individual capacity to fix, nevertheless I propose that whiteness also can be viewed as an attitude that appears in the thinking of individual scholars. We can discern the specific strategies that Beaudoin and Turpin identify—belief in progress, celebratory focus on individual thinkers, and so on—operating in works produced by individuals. Those racialized as white may be particularly likely to exhibit this attitude, especially when working in a culturally white field, because the attitude of whiteness is given to us by virtue of our being white; it shapes our way of being in the world and in our disciplines.

Whiteness as Passive Benevolence

One way that white people commonly exhibit this attitude of whiteness is as a feeling of passive benevolence toward victims of white supremacy. Howard Thurman locates the root of such an attitude in the danger inherent in the Christian missionary impulse:

Again and again our missionary appeal is on the basis of the Christian responsibility to the needy, the ignorant, and the so-called backward peoples of the earth. There is a certain grandeur and nobility in administering

to another's need out of one's fullness and plenty. ... This impulse at the heart of Christianity is the human *will to share* with others what one has found meaningful to oneself elevated to the height of a moral imperative. But there is a lurking danger in this very emphasis. It is exceedingly difficult to hold oneself free from a certain contempt for those whose predicament makes moral appeal for defense and succor. It is the sin of pride and arrogance that has tended to vitiate the missionary impulse and to make of it an instrument of self-righteousness on the one hand and racial superiority on the other.

...For decades we have studied the various peoples of the world and those who live as our neighbors as objects of missionary endeavor and enterprise without being at all willing to treat them either as brothers or as human beings. I say this without rancor, because it is not an issue in which vicious human beings are involved. But it is one of the subtle perils of a religion which calls attention—to the point of overemphasis, sometimes—to one's obligation to administer to human need. (Thurman [1949] 1996, 12–13)

Confident in our own good will and intentions vis-à-vis white supremacy, we express concern for “those less fortunate,” including the victims of white supremacy. We may be willing to help if we can, but, as Thurman indicates, we do not grant their humanity a real claim on us.

If we have never learned to see the reality and destructive effects of white supremacy, then we cannot recognize its victims or the power it confers on us. Indeed, one way that white supremacy perpetuates itself is by concealing itself and our participation in it from our view, so that we do nothing to thwart its continuation. Moreover, it is possible to develop sophisticated knowledge of white supremacy and still take no action to redress it. As Yancy notes regarding racism, a closely related problem, “there is no necessary connection between (a) the ability to reflect critically on white racism, even on *one's own* white racism, and (b) working hard to mark and challenge one's own racist practices” (Yancy 2012, 26). Feeling no personal responsibility to white supremacy, it is not surprising that we feel no urgency to redress it. As Beaudoin and Turpin, Thurman, and other whiteness theorists observe (see Applebaum 2010; Dyer 2008, 12), often no malice is involved. When we notice white supremacy's effects, we may express a heartfelt desire for them to be mitigated. Yet, if those of us with racial power do nothing, even when we do nothing benevolently, the situation is unlikely to change.

In sum, white supremacy structures US society as a force that precedes us, that exists independently of us, and in which we are caught up whether we want to be or not. I contend that whiteness is an attitude that is exhibited

in scholarly method as well as in US society. Method, simply defined, is how we do scholarship. Any attitude that shapes our approach to constructing scholarship may be viewed as constituting an element of our method. Where the attitude of whiteness appears in theology, therefore, it is properly categorized as a component of theological method. Further, if white supremacy is bad—in Christian idiom, if it constitutes a “sign of the times” that we should resist—and whiteness supports white supremacy, then insofar as we can detect whiteness in our scholarship, its presence is no neutral or benign phenomenon but a methodological problem requiring redress. My hypothesis, then, is that the attitude of whiteness pervades conventional theology, and religious studies more broadly, as a methodological problem. Wrestling with this dimension of whiteness, becoming able to see whiteness as our own or our discipline’s default attitude, may be essential for us to recognize that we create white theology and white scholarship generally. In what follows, I aim to render this problem visible by identifying and exposing a particular thought pattern associated with it.

Racist Thinking

Sociologist Steve Martinot (2003, 2010) has put forward a theory of US class formation as grounded in racial formation. The concept of racist thinking is central. In Martinot’s analysis, similar to Mills’s and Massingale’s, the most important aspect of racist thinking is not that individual people think discriminatory thoughts, but that it occurs within an oppressive system.

Martinot explains that racist thinking has a threefold structure: something is granted, something is withheld, and something is maintained.⁸ To demonstrate how this works, Martinot breaks down the “triadic gesture” (Martinot 2003, 9) that occurs when people oppose affirmative action. That argument typically states, “All discrimination is bad; affirmative action privileges some people over others based on race; therefore, affirmative action is bad.” First, the argument states, “All discrimination is bad” (Martinot 2003, 2). The speaker grants that discrimination is bad, implying that this is so self-evident that all reasonable people must agree. Second, the argument states, “Affirmative action privileges some people over others based on race.” In framing this fact as a problem, the speaker withholds essential

⁸Martinot introduces this account in *The Rule of Racialization* (2003) and expands on it in *The Machinery of Whiteness* (2010). Here I summarize his description in *The Rule of Racialization*, in which he argues that the English invented racialization and whiteness over the course of the seventeenth century in the Virginia colony. Ever since, Martinot contends, whiteness has remained a key component of a violent and pernicious US culture of racialization, whose power to divide US Americans exceeds and may even precede that of class struggle.

information: namely, acknowledgment of the actual history of discrimination in which, until very recently, whites took all the spots and allowed none to people of color (Martinot 2003, 2–3, 9). This second step entails a refusal to consider how this history of total discrimination has created an unlevel playing field in the present. Recognition of this history is deemed irrelevant or withheld. Third, the argument concludes, “Therefore, affirmative action is bad.” In this third movement, the speaker maintains her power to be the one who decides the issue. She need not consider alternate perspectives, for her own knowledge is sufficient. She will implement whatever solution she deems appropriate on the basis of only the information that she deems relevant (Martinot 2003, 7). To engage in racist thinking, then, is to grant a general premise framed as self-evident, to withhold acknowledgment of relevant information, and to maintain one’s power to decide what is relevant and to implement the outcome of one’s choice.

Martinot notes that racist thinking evades the normal rules of logic (Martinot 2003, 7). It does so by appearing to follow them while refusing to admit evidence that contests its conclusions. Further, he notes that the effect of eliminating affirmative action in a social system in which discrimination and inequity persist is to allow white supremacy to continue unchecked (Martinot 2003, 3). But because racist thinking refuses interruption, no one can do anything about it: not whites opposed to discrimination, not people of color, not the courts. In fact, Martinot shows that the courts themselves have utilized racist thinking in their so-called “colorblind” deliberations.⁹ Clearly, racist thinking is an effective tool of white supremacy. Although it benefits white people primarily, one need not be white to use it; it can be wielded by anyone.

Martinot exposes racist thinking as a specific, identifiable thought process that promotes whiteness and maintains racial disparities, even when no one consciously intends it. Racist thinking is pervasive in US society. The historically white field of US Catholic theology has arisen within that social context, the field’s practitioners are embedded in that context, and many practitioners are racialized as white. Given all this, it is reasonable to suspect that whiteness functions in US Catholic theology as well as in society in general.

Whiteness in Theological Method

In seeking to detect evidence of the attitude of whiteness in US Catholic theological method, I consider Terrence W. Tilley’s 2008 book *The Disciples’*

⁹As examples, Martinot discusses the Dred Scott decision and recent rulings rolling back affirmative action (Martinot 2003, 3, 6–9). For a well-known treatment of the problems with colorblindness, see Bonilla-Silva 2006.

Jesus: Christology as Reconciling Practice. While there are hundreds of conventional theological scholars whose works are likely to exhibit whiteness, assuming it exists, I focus on Tilley's well-regarded book for two reasons. The first is his crucial insight that who Jesus is and how we should follow him—the person and work of Jesus—cannot be separated, or in Tilley's language, that Christology must be understood as practice. Tilley connects Christology to engagement in the world to a degree remarkable among his peers, in a field that traditionally emphasizes reflection on abstract truths. The second is that Tilley consistently refers to concrete situations in the world and to himself and his experiences. He does not presume that his perspective is universal; on the contrary, he achieves a significant improvement on the long-standing custom of speaking as a disembodied voice floating free of actual events. My intent, then, is not to scapegoat Tilley as exceptionally proficient in whiteness; after all, "to assign a theologian singular responsibility for uncritically furthering white theology fails to address the depth of this cultural practice, as would praising a specific theologian for undermining that repetition" (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 267). On the contrary, my intent is to consider, sympathetically, the work of a relatively self-aware member of the academy. The point of examining *The Disciples' Jesus* is that if we can find whiteness there, in a major, mature work of an acclaimed senior theologian,¹⁰ we are likely to find it everywhere.

I consider *The Disciples' Jesus*, then, as Tilley offers it: as a conventionally constructive contribution to the discipline of theology, specifically Christology. Although I am aware that deep engagement with individual thinkers' groundbreaking ideas is a standard white theological method (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 255), space limitations prohibit detailed treatment of several thinkers here. This method of close textual study is familiar to readers and permits the thorough analysis needed to ascertain whether whiteness is present. I proceed, therefore, with the intent to read Tilley fairly, generously, and honestly.

So, does *The Disciples' Jesus* exhibit whiteness? As discussed above, Tilley need not be racialized as white for whiteness to frame his work. Still, borrowing an insight from Toni Morrison, we can observe that "[Tilley] is white, and we know he is because [he never] says so" (Morrison 1992, 72). Although it is typical for white theologians not to name their whiteness, the fact that Tilley never says so in *The Disciples' Jesus* is striking given the many courageously self-disclosive statements he does make. Here I discuss three moments in the book where Tilley acknowledges

¹⁰Tilley's accomplishments were publicly affirmed in 2012 when he received the Catholic Theological Society of America's John Courtney Murray Award for Distinguished Theological Achievement, a lifetime achievement award that is generally considered to be the highest honor in Catholic theology.

that theologians' identities and locations matter yet remains silent about white supremacy, whiteness, and his own inevitable participation in them. While Tilley's compassion and goodwill are evident throughout, I submit that each of these moments yields evidence of the attitude of whiteness and specifically of racist thinking as Martinot describes it.

The first moment: Early in the book, Tilley acknowledges that "theological construction is undertaken on a particular site" and that this work is constructed "on the U.S. site" (Tilley 2008, 9, 11). As salient features of the US site, he mentions the lack of established religion and resulting absence of a traumatic disestablishment process, the unequal distribution of wealth and the rise of consumerism, and general skepticism about religion (Tilley 2008, 9–10). He makes no mention of the United States' foundation in colonialism, slavery, and genocide; the role Christianity and white Christians played in establishing that foundation; or the fact that that foundation still undergirds the United States's unequal distribution of wealth and power. Moreover, Tilley acknowledges that "theologians each occupy a particular social location on [any] site" and that "these locations increase the chances of particular insights and oversights" (Tilley 2008, 9). Yet, rather than taking the logical next step and discussing how his own identity matters to this specific project, Tilley remarks, "Latin American liberation theologians, for example, work from the perspective of the poor and oppressed," and goes on to identify some of the strengths and weaknesses of their work in their context, which is not his own (Tilley 2008, 9). In sum, Tilley acknowledges that site and identity matter to theology, yet does not discuss how his site and his identity matter to his theology.

In terms of the dynamics of racist thinking, Tilley grants that the site of his book and the identity of its author are important; he withholds key facts about that site and identity; and he maintains that he can write a relevant US-based theology without grappling with those facts. Although he does not articulate this belief explicitly, the fact that Tilley moved the work forward to publication demonstrates that he considered the argument to be sufficiently framed and reasonably complete, and the length and thoroughness of the work suggest that he did not intentionally omit anything that he believed essential.

The second moment: In the conclusion to part I, discussing Elisabeth Schüssler Fiorenza's notion of kyriarchy, Tilley makes an admission that is rare indeed: he is an "elite, academic male." He states that if members of this "tribe" are not part of the solution, then they are part of the problem (Tilley 2008, 68). At first glance, this seems promising. Yet this acknowledgment of his privilege (he does not use this word) does not appear until page sixty-eight, which indicates that he does not see it as germane to his argument.

In fact, as Tilley continues this discussion, rather than critiquing his privilege, he claims another advantage that accrues from it, namely that “when it is not possible to overthrow the system of oppression, then even we educated elite can learn from the discourse practices of the oppressed” (Tilley 2008, 69). Having considered Mary McClintock Fulkerson’s study of Appalachian women’s discourses of resistance, Tilley reflects,

We [elite academic males] can learn not only something about how the confession “Jesus is Lord” has been abused in the past and is abused in the present to support “kyriarchy” but also how to critically reconstruct, theologize about, act in the service of—and even pray to—the Lord Jesus in our own discourses in a manner like that of the Appalachian wo/men to whom Fulkerson gives a voice. Yet we can never forget how easy it is to tame or hijack a practice of resistance and emancipation that uses the Lord’s tools to deconstruct the lords’ controlling discourses. (Tilley 2008, 69)

This reminder, though cleverly worded—evoking Audre Lorde’s warning that “the master’s tools will never dismantle the master’s house” (Lorde 1984, 112)—is quite vague: What the oppressor can learn from the oppressed, apparently by copying them, is “something about...how to...act” and deploy “discourse” more “critically.” Is Tilley overidentifying with the oppressed here? He runs a discernible risk of inappropriately appropriating their creative strategies for resistance, for it is unclear that this sort of learning would motivate elites to work to stop oppression.

Moreover, Tilley himself forecloses this possibility by limiting his discussion to situations in which “it is not possible to overthrow the system of oppression” (Tilley 2008, 69). This foreclosure seems odd. Oppressed people remain oppressed because they do not have the power to “overthrow the system” that oppresses them. Recall Yancy’s observation that for people of color, whiteness appears “in the form of embodied whites who engage in racist practices that negatively affect their lives” (Yancy 2012, 7). Oppressors, in whom the system invests the power, could “overthrow the system” at any time; the only thing lacking is the will to do so. If we do not recognize this, then of course we will never “overthrow the system.” Yet Tilley characterizes “the power of oppression” as an impersonal force: “There was no time when the power of oppression was not. It has always been a factor in the community of disciples, a factor to be resisted” (Tilley 2008, 69). Perhaps, like many on the advantaged side of a power divide, Tilley has not considered that in an oppressive system some people are accurately described as oppressors and that he might fall into this category. In fact, Tilley never acknowledges his whiteness, which arguably

undergirds and confers even greater social power than the considerable advantages he receives as an “elite, academic male.”¹¹

In terms of racist thinking, then, Tilley grants that social location, including his own social location, makes a difference; he withholds acknowledgment of his racialization as white, as well as of the possibility that this fact renders him an oppressor; and he maintains—again, without saying so explicitly—that he can construct an adequate US-based Christology without addressing his racial location or how, as a member of US society and the author of this Christology, he himself may be functioning as an oppressor.

The third moment: Part III of the book presents the four main “reconciling practices” that Tilley develops in detail. In terms of our concern with whiteness, perhaps the most significant passage occurs here, when Tilley considers the “reconciling practice” of forgiveness. Quoting Robert Schreiter, Tilley asks: “How does one even begin to forgive ‘the genocides of Armenia and Cambodia, the Holocaust, the tyranny of Communist governments, the effects of imperialism on colonized peoples, the global wars and the ethnic conflicts?’” (Tilley 2008, 169–70). Expressing uncertainty over his role in all this, Tilley muses, “As I am neither an Armenian, a Cambodian, a victim of the Shoah, a tyrannical regime, or a colonialist, a supporter of global wars or ethnic cleansing (except in the social complicity of all of us due in part to globalization), what good is my forgiveness? *Who* is to forgive in practice is an issue that needs to be explored” (Tilley 2008, 170). Surely many readers share Tilley’s bemusement. His mention of “social complicity” gestures toward a brilliant and uncommon insight. As Jon Sobrino (2008, 99–108; see also Vasko 2015) points out, in a world where there are victims and nonvictims, nonvictims are complicit in events like these; any nonvictim who does not work actively for the liberation of victims may be viewed as a perpetrator. Tilley knows that he is among the nonvictims, and he bravely wonders about his role. Yet he does not wonder whether nonvictims, such as himself, may be responsible to address these events and their effects. He does not wonder whether we may be the ones who need to be forgiven, the ones who need to make amends.

Here again, Tilley unwittingly misses an obvious opportunity due to the pernicious operation of racist thinking: he grants that atrocities have taken place, and that forgiveness may be a relevant concept; he withholds acknowledgement that as a nonvictim and beneficiary of white supremacy, he may have a personal responsibility to address the ongoing legacy of imperialism and colonialism; and he maintains his authority to shape the

¹¹This may be an example of what Bonilla-Silva (2006) calls “racism without racists.”

theological agenda, by asserting a rather strange question about “who is to forgive,” rather than trying to imagine what the victims’ questions or priorities might be, let alone asking them.

In each of these moments—Tilley’s description of the US “site” and the importance of theologians’ identities, his self-identification as an “elite, academic male,” and his parenthetical acknowledgement of the “social complicity of us all”—Tilley grants that location, identity, and complicity matter; he withholds acknowledgment of the foundational significance of racism and white supremacy, and of his own racial location; and he maintains the power to produce and determine what counts as Christology. Racist thinking thus operates to obscure key features of the site, author, and implications of the argument, even though the author’s consistent and genuine goodwill could not be more evident.

The project’s overall structure provides further confirmation. Tilley’s initial assertion that context and social location matter to theological arguments is belied by the fact that, as it turns out, they do not matter to his argument. He does not frame his discussion with an issue arising from the United States’ lack of established religion, nor does he address in any sustained manner the unequal distribution of wealth, though he names these as salient factors at the outset. Nor does he systematically examine any elements of his own social location, such as race, gender, or class, as shaping his perspective. Rather, he begins and ends, as theologians are wont to do, with his personal interests: he explains how the book extends his own previous work; he dialogues mainly with other white thinkers; and he concludes with theoretical reflections on reconciliation, discipleship, a Vatican II document, and resurrection. This matches Beaudoin and Turpin’s description of “white theology,” mentioned above, as prioritizing the ideas of individual thinkers building on the ideas of individual thinkers (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 255). Tilley intends his account to be relevant to justice issues; he wants to promote “reconciling practices” in the real world. But in mentioning many contexts and examples, giving deep attention to none, he seems to attempt to apply his theory everywhere without grounding it anywhere. The outcome is a deeply thoughtful, consciously benevolent, geographically fragmented, thoroughly intellectualized Christology that ignores “the unnamed political system that has made the modern world what it is today”: white supremacy (Mills 1997, 1).

Ultimately, Tilley reframes the Great Commission to require teaching the practices of reconciliation rather than specific beliefs (Tilley 2008, 254–55). Theoretically, this conclusion is compelling. Yet the application is unsatisfying. In his New Testament-focused discussions of Christology’s central “reconciling practices”—healing, teaching, forgiveness, and table

fellowship and hospitality—Tilley tasks the reader with figuring out what these practices could look like rather than constructing in-depth proposals himself. If he had recognized his participation, “on the U.S. site,” in the ongoing legacy of slavery, genocide, and colonialism, he might have illustrated the “reconciling practices” that constitute his Christology through reflection on actual justice issues that arose while he was writing. For example, what did the “reconciling practices” of healing, teaching, forgiveness, and table fellowship and hospitality look like—or what could they have looked like—in the wake of Hurricane Katrina? Such an in-depth case study could have constituted a concrete and compelling conclusion.

We should not excuse this lack of a concrete proposal on the grounds that Tilley frames his book as a work of systematic theology and not ethics. To use theoretical distinctions as excuses to abdicate our responsibility to imagine actions for justice we could undertake in our own contexts is to refuse to love our neighbor as ourselves (Mark 12:31). The problem is deeper than the issue of disciplinary division of labor. I maintain that it is methodological. Whiteness, and in particular the unwitting deployment of racist thinking, functions to prevent Tilley from tackling concrete, focused questions. Unnoticed by himself, Tilley’s whiteness undercuts his sincere commitment to justice, framed as reconciling practices. In blinding him to the significance of his social location and to his participatory role in the injustices around him, racist thinking functions as a methodological problem that undermines the power of Tilley’s argument for Christology as reconciling practice.

My point is not that Tilley’s contribution has no value. Far from it. *The Disciples’ Jesus* is carefully researched, elegantly argued, and makes a vital point about Christology as practice. It is also worth repeating that Tilley does not bear unique accountability for the problem of racist thinking; the effect of racism in the discipline is cumulative over centuries, and responsibility is shared collectively (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 267). My point is to notice that racist thinking keeps Tilley from being fully and consciously rooted where he actually is. The attitude of whiteness renders his argument less effective and relevant than it could be. And if such a well-intentioned, seasoned theologian’s work can be so shaped by whiteness, then we must wonder whether whiteness characterizes his discipline generally.

I suspect that theologians, especially those of us who are white, engage in racist thinking as a matter of course: We grant that justice is needed, we withhold recognition that we are responsible to bring it about, and we maintain our power to decide what is truly interesting or urgent. If I am right, then racist thinking is a thought pattern that occurs as a component of the attitude of whiteness in theology. Further study would be needed to determine whether there are other such patterns, or whether racist

thinking is itself the central thought-mechanism of whiteness. Either way, this attitude occurs within a discipline whose most powerful architects—white theologians—are still constructing it according to white cultural values and norms. These values and norms warrant scrutiny, not only because they are culturally specific rather than universal, but also because white culture is not neutral but is rooted in domination.

To summarize: The attitude of whiteness, including racist thinking, involves feeling passively benevolent toward people who are oppressed by white supremacy, especially when we do not recognize it as such; exercising powerblindness and believing that we, personally and collectively, are not implicated in these problems; and failing to work toward solving them. Christian whiteness consists in thinking that maintaining a benevolent attitude fulfills our obligation to obey Jesus' exhortations to justice and mercy. In theology, whiteness comes into view in well-meaning treatises that, though expressing deep concern for victims of injustice, nevertheless exhibit ignorance of white supremacy both personally and systemically, along with a lack of personal commitment to bring in justice in concrete situations circumscribed by it. In perpetuating unexamined whiteness (see Townes 2006, chap. 4) and racist thinking, *The Disciples' Jesus*, like many other works, unintentionally commits what Cone (2004) calls "theology's great sin: silence in the face of white supremacy."

ANTIRACIST THINKING AS SCHOLARLY METHOD

The situation is dire, but it is not hopeless. Already there are some works in US religious studies and theology that, though emerging from the field's culturally white disciplinary framework, do not exhibit racist thinking. These authors deploy what I call "antiracist thinking," a methodological approach that accounts for white supremacy and their own racialization. As an example, this final section briefly compares M. Shawn Copeland's *Enfleshing Freedom: Body, Race, and Being* with *The Disciples' Jesus*. Within the discipline of Catholic theology, recent works by white theologians that tackle white supremacy include Grimes 2017, Hill Fletcher 2017, Pramuk 2013, and Vasko 2015. I highlight Copeland precisely because, in addition to the reasons outlined earlier, *Enfleshing Freedom* does not take white supremacy as its primary theme. Rather, it deals with the relevant dimensions of white supremacy while constructively exploring the meaning of human bodies, a major theme in theological anthropology. *Enfleshing Freedom* is thus a closer parallel to *The Disciples' Jesus*, which, I have argued, should have attended to white supremacy even as its subject was Christology. The comparison illuminates how this can be done.

Enfleshing Freedom and *The Disciples' Jesus* are both works of systematic theology and have similar aims. Although Copeland and Tilley locate their works in different areas—anthropology and Christology, respectively—both focus on Christian discipleship as requiring specific concrete practices. Tilley's "fundamental approach is that Christology begins in disciples' imaginations and is realized by engaging in the reconciling practices that constitute discipleship" (Tilley 2008, 1); Copeland exhorts her readers to cultivate "discipleship [as] the practice of solidarity with and beside and among 'the least'" (Copeland 2010, 6). Similarly, both aspire to produce theologies that are relevant to concrete issues. Tilley hopes to reshape Christology such that it leads organically to "reconciling practices," whereas Copeland aims to create "a theological anthropology worthy of reclaiming black women's bodies...human bodies" (Tilley 2008, xi; Copeland 2010, 6).

Yet these two works are also very different. That the authors feel differently about their books is clear in the tone that each takes in introducing their work. Addressing the reader, Tilley says of his book, "I am excited to present it to you; I hope it stimulates your faith and your reflection on your faith" (Tilley 2008, xi). Clearly, Tilley has enjoyed writing the book and expects us to enjoy reading it. For her part, Copeland warns the reader that the journey on which her narrative takes us will be "difficult" and "strenuous," that it will depict "black bodies in pain" as it takes up "the aching memory of slavery" (Copeland 2010, 5–6). She struggled to write this book, and expects that we may struggle as we read it. Why such a difference, when both books take up real, urgent human problems and the deep need for solidarity and reconciliation?

One way to name the difference is to say that whiteness characterizes Tilley's approach, but not Copeland's. First, notice how each approaches his or her own relationship to the subject. Tilley, we have seen, often does not implicate himself in the problems he discusses. He comes across as a kind, interested observer who hopes that his intellectual labors, including reflection on his own experiences, will motivate readers to work for justice in their contexts. Copeland identifies herself "as a theologian who is black and a woman" at the outset, and the fact that her identity is bound up in her subject is abundantly clear (Copeland 2010, 3). On the dedication page, she holds herself accountable to black women whose bodies have been destroyed by the everyday operations of white supremacy: the middle passage, slavery, lynching, defilement. She also remembers her "grandmother[,] Mattie Hunt Billingslea[,] whose bodily labor made my freedom possible" (Copeland 2010, v). Copeland states that her "responsibility to these dead" has led her to this project (Copeland 2010, 4). Noting that "the Christian gospel is an invitation to *metanoia*, to change," she

tells us that she seeks to construct “a theological anthropology worthy of reclaiming black women’s bodies,” which will also be “worthy of reclaiming *human* bodies” (Copeland 2010, 6). Rather than creating an individualistic focus on herself and her ideas, Copeland’s self-awareness locates her as a member of the community from which she speaks.¹² Antiracist thinking grounds the project, personalizing it in a way that does not limit its scope but instead renders it widely relevant. Although ultimately she hopes to “reclaim *human* bodies,” Copeland does not begin by assuming her project’s universal relevance.¹³ It emerges organically for the reader who attends deeply to how black women have enfleshed freedom.

Second, whereas Tilley introduces new issues at every turn, Copeland builds her reflections around one theme: she honors black women, from Saartjie Baartman, a Khosian woman who was exhibited as a curiosity and died in nineteenth-century Europe, to Fatima Yusif, a Somali woman who gave birth before a jeering crowd by the side of a road in Italy in 1992. Copeland tells their stories to expose the lie of white supremacy, to compel us to contemplate our own participation in it. Copeland’s theology is accountable to Jesus rather than about Jesus, and through it runs a thread of resurrection hope. Jesus, the crucified one, “does not forget poor, dark, and despised bodies” (Copeland 2010, 53); black women’s discarded bodies are not meaningless but have eternal value and will one day be raised. Copeland’s theologically sophisticated account ranges across the world in pursuit of its aim. Yet it remains grounded in a concrete historical situation: the shameful treatment and destruction, and the resistance and survival, of black women’s bodies. Readers can follow Copeland’s example in locating ourselves in relation to these bodies.

Third, Copeland’s stated goal is not primarily to reshape an academic discipline, nor to convince others to theologize differently. Rather, she is concerned to fulfill her obligation to the “Many Thousand Gone” (Copeland 2010, 3). Here the dynamics of racist thinking are not to be found; there is no granting of carefully chosen premises, no withholding of relevant data, no unwitting maintaining of power to define the situation being discussed at the expense of victims’ voices. Copeland sees how white supremacy deforms all of our lives, and she does not shy away from it. In revealing what white supremacy does to black women, and in speaking consciously from her own social location, she invites readers to hear her argument consciously from our own social locations and to inquire into our relationships to black women’s enfleshment of freedom.

¹²By contrast, Beaudoin and Turpin note that “the experience of the individual person” is central to white practical theology (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 255).

¹³Recall that Beaudoin and Turpin critique white theology’s propensity for assuming its own universal relevance without awareness of its own social location (Beaudoin and Turpin 2014, 254).

What would happen if white US theologians and religious studies scholars accepted responsibility to the “Many Thousand Gone”? to black men, women, and children killed by police and their surrogates? to Syrian refugees? to transgender people? to parents and children entering the US without documentation? to dispossessed First Nations peoples? What “compassionate practices of solidarity” (Copeland 2010, 4) might we be compelled to undertake? How might our scholarship be transformed?

CONCLUSION

White supremacy has been a governing principle in US society and churches since before the nation was founded. Yet theologians and scholars of religion rarely address it. In maintaining that the attitude of whiteness pervades our scholarship, I have identified some operations of racist thinking in one book and of antiracist thinking in another. I have argued that racist thinking functions within white theological methodology to prevent us from incorporating into our work a full account of our social situation and our racial participation in it. To construct adequate and relevant arguments, white theologians and scholars of religion who are committed to truth and justice must critically engage white supremacy, including our own whiteness.

If we suspect that our scholarship exhibits whiteness, can we work toward recognizing and interrupting our own racist thinking? Can we alter our commitments? Perhaps. I conclude with three brief suggestions for where we might begin.

First, we can learn our own histories. When did our families arrive here and on what terms? What were and are our experiences vis-à-vis the dynamics of white supremacy? Do these dynamics afford us unearned privileges? Do they oppress us? Following Copeland’s example, we can develop a sense of our own roles as participants in this white supremacist US culture and allow this groundedness to shape the way we think theologically and religiously.

Second, as scholars, we are trained to think first and act second. But, as do the teachings of many religious and nonreligious traditions, Jesus challenges Christians to act compassionately and let our attitudes follow. In his story of the Good Samaritan, when a man is attacked by robbers, the neighbor is the one who acts to move the injured man to a safe place, not the one who feels bad for him and announces to others that something must be done. That person didn’t even make it into the story. Internalizing this reversal could change everything.

Third, we can participate in the movements that Jesus—who transcended religious boundaries, appealing to those who shared his Jewishness as well as to those who did not—surely would join if he were here. Where are the struggles in our communities? How can we be involved? Not on our terms, unless it is our struggle, but on the terms of the people whose well-being is at stake. And if, after undertaking these commitments, it still seems important to generate scholarship, we can let it flow from them.

Given our embeddedness in this white supremacist culture (Yancy 2012, chap. 6), it is likely that those of us who are white can never definitively overcome our whiteness, including in our scholarship. What we may be able to do is to begin to see it, catch it in the act, and take responsibility for it. From there, perhaps we can begin to conspire¹⁴ with like-minded people to provoke moments in which white supremacy no longer reigns supreme, in which justice and mercy can gain the upper hand, however fleetingly.

EPILOGUE

I initially submitted this article to a prominent theological journal, which rejected it.¹⁵ Readers interested in testing the method of analysis that I have piloted here may wish to consider whether whiteness was operating in that journal's reasoning, since—presumably with good intentions and without malice—the decision functioned to protect the field and its most powerful members from having to face our whiteness.

Although my argument was deemed effective, the primary stated objection was that publishing it would be unfair to Professor Tilley because it would make him the poster child for whiteness in theology when many scholars are equally culpable. I was encouraged to submit a new manuscript on the topic, perhaps critiquing whiteness in my own work. Because the first article I ever published as a newly minted PhD does not address white supremacy explicitly, this would be possible, and I remain open to doing it. But I thought that it would be far more effective to introduce the concept by engaging a full-length work by a widely known and respected senior scholar. Still, having no desire to harm Tilley's reputation, I took this objection seriously.

On reflection, I decided to trust readers' ability to consider whiteness as a disciplinary problem. Critical engagement with exemplary individuals'

¹⁴Following Alicia Garza, Black Lives Matter co-founder, I use the word *conspire* in the sense of "breathing together." Alicia Garza, speech at University of San Diego, February 27, 2015.

¹⁵For a concluding reflection in a similar vein, see Williams 1991, 214–15. I thank Dr. Greg Prieto for calling my attention to this precedent.

ideas is standard practice in theology—especially white theology, as Beaudoin and Turpin note (2014, 255)—and need not be confused with character assassination. Moreover, Tilley has already won the highest award available in Catholic theology, and his career is so far advanced that he has not only attained an endowed chair at Fordham University but has retired from it. One can hardly imagine a living scholar less in need of protection. I concluded that Tilley's reputation is so solidly established that a constructive critique cannot possibly do it any harm; and if he reads this analysis, I hope he agrees that it may do our field some good.

In sum, the journal justified its rejection by appealing to the perceived need to protect a self-described “elite academic male,” whose career is substantively complete, from an argument about whiteness that *might* be misconstrued as singling him out as uniquely accountable.¹⁶ The argument was that I should not hold anyone (besides myself) responsible for whiteness, lest other responsible parties escape scrutiny (notice how the logic disintegrates); I should not critique anyone if no one (else) is being critiqued; I should not critique anyone who does not critique herself. This last might seem practical given the touchiness of the subject. But if the only appropriate way for my whiteness to come to my attention is for me to notice it, then the implication is that my whiteness is not important enough for anyone else to notice it. It is more important for others to humor my belief that my benevolent intentions render me a benign presence in the world than to point out my whiteness. If confronting whiteness is appropriate only as a voluntary exercise in self-improvement, then confronting whiteness is not important.

Though clearly well-intended, this objection finally appears to be “a case of...reasoning in the name of social justice against all social justice” (Martinot 2003, 7). In the alternative logic of racist thinking, it grants that theology has a whiteness problem; withholds acknowledgment that exposing this problem may be important enough to warrant implicating a single prominent scholar, and that readers have—or ought to have—the intellectual and moral fortitude to discern the broader implications; and maintains the power to preserve the status quo of silence. To remain silent when all are culpable is to assert that all are innocent.

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¹⁶This argument appears to exhibit “white fragility,” a process whites commonly use to protect ourselves from having to confront society's racial hierarchy and our place in it (DiAngelo 2018, 2). My thanks to Dr. Seth Schoen for noting this connection.

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